THE FIGHT FOR POLITICAL CAPITAL

Leading the campaign as non-playing captains or taking the electoral field themselves, a whole range of political players exemplify the churn that Punjab's politics is going through

BY ANILESH S. MAHAJAN

Going along National Highways 44 and 3, cutting through Punjab after crossing the Shambhu barrier, giant hoardings promoting the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) candidates for the Lok Sabha election dot the entire 220-km journey to the border city of Amritsar. A stern-visaged Bhagwant Mann, the Punjab chief minister, stares down these posters, the look only accentuated by the neatly tied yellow turban and perfectly dyed and trimmed beard. His is the most imposing presence on the poster; the images of other candidates accompanying him smaller in size, the emblazoned message in Gurmukhi leaving no one in any doubt—'*Sansad Vich vi Bhagwant Mann*' (Bhagwant Mann in Parliament too). There's a 'photoshopped' image of national convenor Arvind Kejriwal, too, showing him behind bars—an attempt perhaps to corner the sympathy vote—but Mann clearly remains the centrepiece. It is a subtle departure, as it is usually Kejriwal who is the main draw wherever the AAP attempts to expand its reach.

Mann, a comedian-turned-neta known for his rustic humour, had stormed to power in March 2022, with the AAP capturing 92 of the 117 assembly seats and securing 42 per cent of the vote share—a feat no political party had achieved since present-day Punjab's inception in 1966. Now, as the state prepares to elect all its 13 Lok Sabha members on June 1, Mann is calling the shots within the AAP—from the selection of candidates and campaign strategies to mobilisation of resources—with minimal interference from the party's national high command. At least, that is the impression one gets, given Rajya Sabha MP Raghav Chadha's absence due to health reasons and his parliamentary colleague Sandeep Pathak maintaining a low profile. This resonates well with a section of Punjabi society that harbours sub-regional aspirations and resents their chief minister's subservience to the Delhi-based bosses—a sentiment more prevalent in the Malwa region, from where Mann comes.

On joining office two years ago, Mann was perceived as taking orders



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THE PARTY'S FACE

BHAGWANT MANN
Chief Minister

USP: He is the flag-bearer of Punjab AAP, which is seeking votes in his name, and not of the candidates or party supremo Arvind Kejriwal

But: His two-year-old government is facing anti-incumbency